
Amy Beach

1867–1944, AMERICAN

The first US woman composer to have major works performed, Beach was born Amy Marcy Cheney, descended from a distinguished New England family. Her outstanding musical ability was noticed from an early age and she gave her first piano recital in Boston at the age of 16. After she married in 1885, she curtailed her performing career to focus on composition, becoming the only female member of the Boston-based composers known as the Second New England School. In a long creative life she wrote a wide range of music, including a choral Mass, a symphony, chamber works, solo piano pieces, and songs, some of which proved popular and lucrative. After her husband's death in 1910, she traveled to Europe, where her work was well received. Returning to the US, from the 1920s she wrote most of her music at the MacDowell artists' colony in New Hampshire.

KEY WORKS: Gaelic Symphony in E major, Op. 32, 1897; Piano Concerto in C-sharp major, Op. 45, 1899; Variations on Balkan Themes (piano solo), Op. 60, 1904; The Cantic of the Sun (soloists, choir and orchestra), Op. 123, 1924